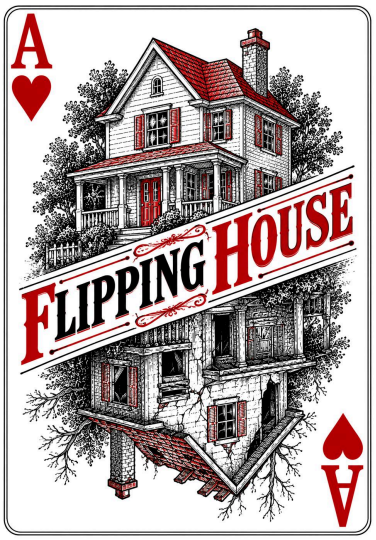
Flipping House



1 player | Ages 12+ | 15 min

Overview

Flipping House is a solitaire card game about managing four properties. Each property is a two-sided pile of cards. Renovate a house by playing a higher card on it, then flip the entire pile. Each renovation forces a house to deteriorate, which might lead to a chain reaction. Try to last the entire deck while keeping all four properties from crumbling to dust.

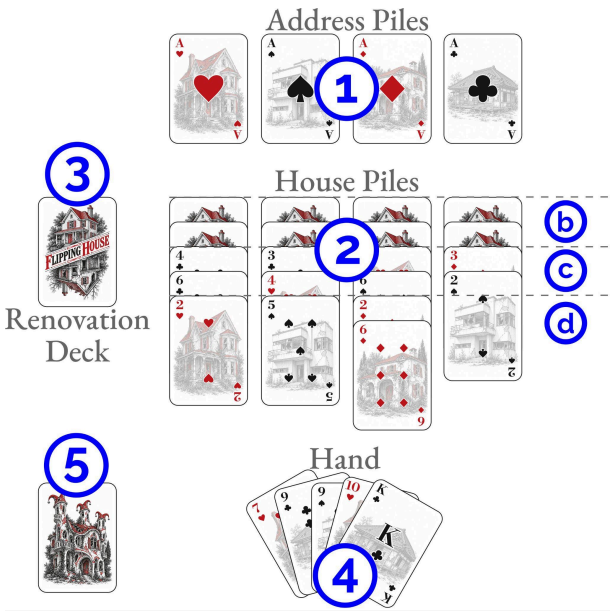
Components

One standard 52-card deck. For an easier variant, add one Joker.

Goal

Play through the entire Renovation Deck and your hand without condemning any house. **You lose immediately** if a house exposes a face-down card or you cannot make a legal renovation.

Setup



1. Separate the four Aces and place them face up in a row. These are the start of the **Address Piles** identifying your houses by suit.
2. Prepare your **House Piles**; each House will be a pile of cards below each Ace:
   a. Shuffle all twenty cards ranked 2 through 6.
   b. Deal one card face down onto each house, below the Aces, left to right. Repeat for a second face-down round.
   c. Now deal one card face up onto each house, still on top of the previous (face-down) cards. Repeat for a second face-up round.
   d. Place each of the four remaining cards face up on the house matching its suit. A house may receive several of these cards, or none.
3. Shuffle the remaining cards (7 through King) into a face-down Renovation Deck.
4. Draw 5 cards into your hand.
5. **For an easy variant**: keep 1 Joker in reach.

Terms and Concepts

Address Piles

A House is identified by the suit of its Address Pile above. Each of the four Address Piles start with a single Ace. Whenever you are instructed to place a card on its Address Pile, place it on top of the Address Pile matching the card's suit (♥ cards go on the ♥ Address Pile, ♣ cards onto ♣ Address Pile, and so on).

House Piles

Each two-sided pile below an Address Pile represents a single House. One side of each House represents its interior, the other its exterior (although it doesn't matter which is which). You can only work with the face-up cards of a House Pile, and will sometimes need to flip it to shift your attention to the other side. When you are instructed to flip a House, turn over the entire pile as a single stack.

Cards in a House Pile can be of any suit, they don't have to match the suit of their Address Pile, nor the suit of other cards in the House Pile.

You may always look at all face-up cards in a House Pile. You may never inspect its face-down portion, but you may count its number of face-down cards. To make that easy, you may choose to keep your House Pile splayed downwards like in the setup diagram instead of keeping it condensed as a single stack.

If a House Pile ever has a face-down card on top, you lose immediately.

Card Ranks

Cards are ranked A, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, J, Q, K.

Gameplay

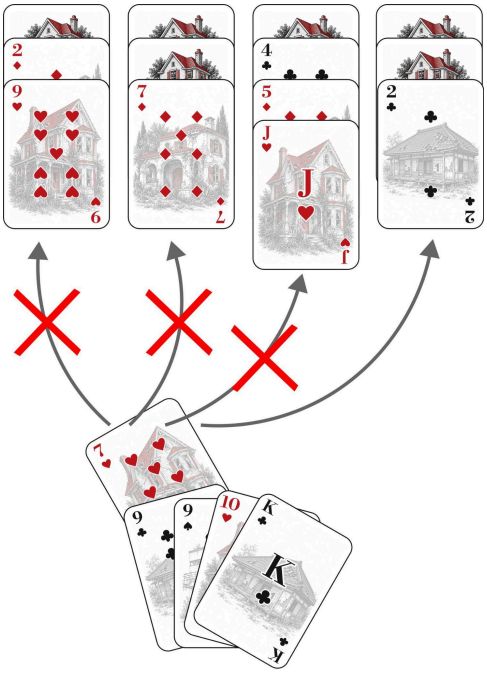
Play turns until you win or lose. Each turn follows three steps: 1. Renovate > 2. Deteriorate > 3. Draw.

Renovate

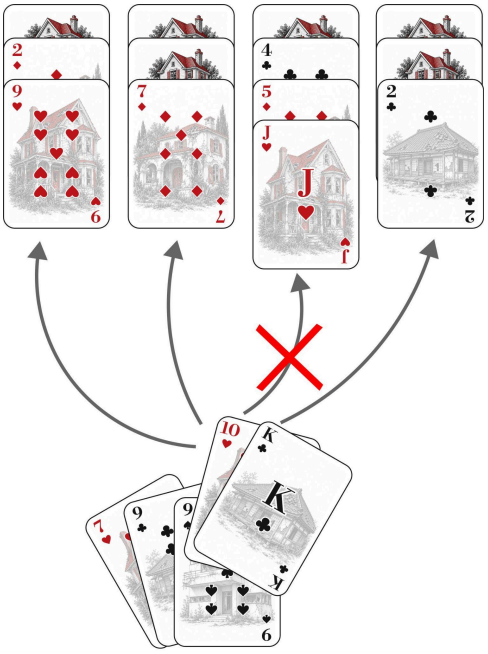
You **must** renovate exactly one House by playing one or two cards from your hand face-up onto a House Pile of your choice. The first card must be strictly higher in rank than the House's visible top card. There are no suit restrictions.

- Normal Renovation: Play one higher card onto a House Pile of your choice.
- Double Renovation: Play two cards onto a House Pile of your choice. Both cards must be played onto the same House, one after the other. The first one must be higher than the House's current top card, and the second must be higher than the first. Both cards may have a different suit.

If you cannot play a legal move, you lose immediately.



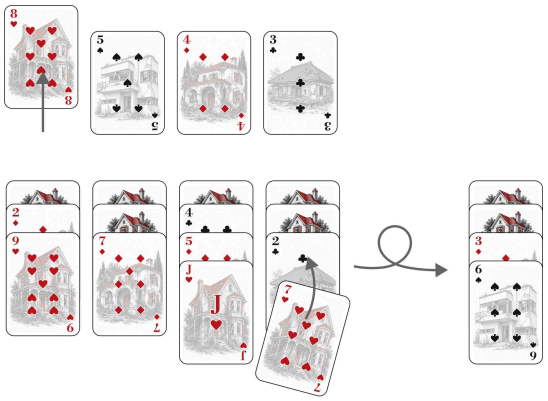
Ellen wants to play her 7♥ as a Normal Renovation. She may only play it on a House Pile if that increases its top card's rank, and hence can only do so on the rightmost House.



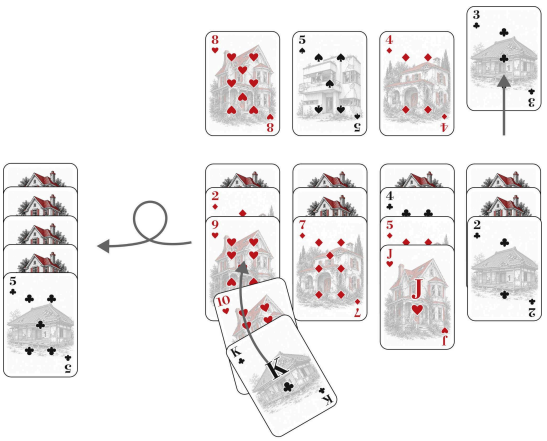
*Jeremy wants to play a Double Renovation using his **10♥** and **K♣**. He must first play the **10** followed by the **K**. The third House Pile already has a top card higher than or equal to 10, and hence cannot be played to. Jeremy can play them to any of the other Houses.*

Next, identify the Address matching the suit of the renovation card you played. If you performed a Double Renovation, you may choose an Address matching any of the 2 suits played. That Address identifies the House that deteriorates this turn. It is possible that during a turn the same House is renovated and deteriorates.

Now flip the entire renovated House Pile as a single stack.



Having played the 7♥ on the rightmost House, Ellen slides the ♥ Address Pile a bit upwards to remember she played a ♥ and this House will deteriorate later. She then flips the House Pile on which she just played, revealing its other side.



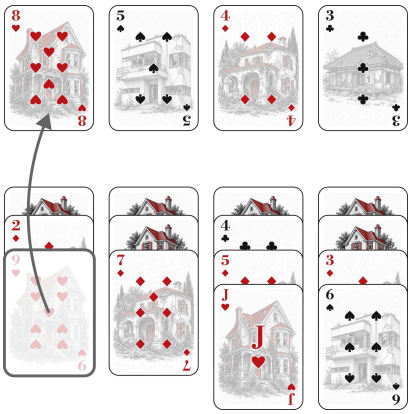
*After playing the **10♥** and **K♣** on the leftmost House, Jeremy may choose which of the ♥ or ♣ House will deteriorate later. He chooses the ♣ and shifts the ♣ Address Pile a bit upwards. He then flips the House Pile on which he just played, revealing its other side.*

Deteriorate

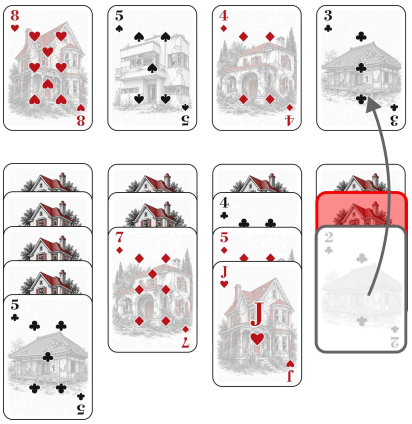
Each turn will see at least one House Pile deteriorating, and possibly more.

Start with the House belonging to the Address identified during the Renovate step. Resolve deterioration as follows:

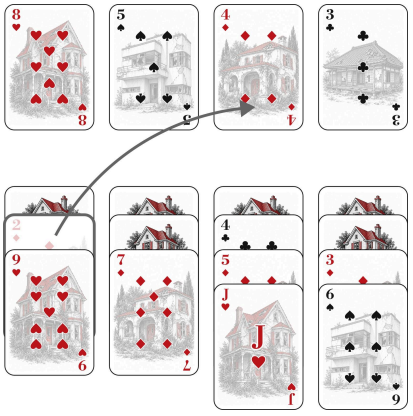
1. Choose any face-up card on that House's currently visible side. Remove it without changing the order of the other cards. Do not flip the House. **If by doing so, the new top-most card of a House Pile is face-down, you lose immediately.**
2. Place the removed card face up onto the Address Pile matching its suit.
3. Compare the removed card with the card that was previously on top of that Address. If the new card is higher, deterioration stops. If it is lower, the house matching that Address must deteriorate also. Repeat these steps until the card you place on an Address is higher than the card you cover.



*Ellen needs to deteriorate the ♥ House Pile. She chooses to remove the **9♥**, which consequently needs to be placed on top of the ♥ Address Pile. Since **9** is a higher rank than **8**, deterioration stops after this single occurrence.*



Jeremy needs to deteriorate the ♣ House Pile. There's only one face-up card in that pile, so he can't choose. Removing that card from the House Pile reveals a face-down card, meaning the ♣ House has crumbled to dust. You should take better care of your houses Jeremy, you lose!



*If Ellen would choose to deteriorate with the **2♦** instead, this would cause a new deterioration of the ♦ House (since the newly placed **2** on the ♦ Address Pile is lower than the **4** which was already present at the top). Consequently, she would have to choose to remove one of the **4♣**, **5♦**, **J♥** of the ♦ House and place it on its corresponding Address Pile. None of these choices would cause a new deterioration.*

Draw

Draw one card from the Renovation Deck if possible. Never draw more than one card per turn. When the Renovation Deck runs out, continue playing the cards left in your hand without drawing replacements.

Note: A Double Renovation uses two cards but replaces only one. Your hand is therefore one card smaller for the rest of the game, reducing your flexibility. You can double-renovate again in a later turn if you still hold at least two cards.

Game End

You win when the Renovation Deck and your hand are both empty, after resolving all deterioration from your final renovation. Winning the game is already quite a feat. If you'd like, sum the ranks of the top cards on your 4 Property Deed to calculate your final score.

You lose immediately if any of the following happens:

- A House reveals a face-down card on top (i.e. when removing its last face-up card).
- No card in your hand can legally renovate any House. You are not allowed to pass or discard a card.

Easy Variant

In the Easy Variant, you have one Joker available which acts like both a wild card and a reset:

- When Renovating, you may choose to play the one Joker set aside during setup instead of a card from your hand. You may **not** double renovate using a Joker though.
- The Joker has no rank and no suit. It may be played onto any House Pile, and you may choose the Address (Suit) of the House that will deteriorate.
- While on top of a House Pile, any card may be played on the Joker. It effectively counts as rank 0, so you can use it to reset the values you may play on top of it.
- When moving the Joker from a House Pile to an Address Pile, you may choose which Address Pile to move it to, and it never causes a chained deterioration. The Address Pile keeps its main suit though (i.e. the ♣ Address Pile remains the ♣ Address Pile).
- Likewise, while on top of an Address Pile, a card of any rank (suit still matching that of the Address Pile) may be placed on the Joker, without triggering a chained deterioration.
- After having Renovated with a Joker, still draw a new card to your hand.

Strategy Tips

- Use Double Renovations wisely, they are very powerful but reduce the flexibility of your hand. Nevertheless, the advantages of a Double Renovation are:
    - You pad one side of a House Pile with extra protection.
    - You get a choice as to which House Pile will deteriorate.
    - You avoid one deterioration which would've otherwise happened if playing the cards separately.